

REEN OF THE DUSTBOUND VOYAGE (AKA MORDRUN STRONGLIMB) SCENE

We start on a humming, blue screen, the light is obscured by the back of a white badge. It then flashes green with an accompanying "ping". Our view slowly pulls back, a thick dwarven hand takes the badge from the scanner and clips it onto the breast of a worn brown jacket. Mordrun Stronglimb steps through the checkpoint and into the concourse, pulling a small piece of luggage behind him. The station is crowded, travelers moving in both directions beneath large hanging signs pointing towards docking platforms, transit lines, and service offices. Mordrun moves with them, looking up towards one of the departure boards, then down towards the ticket on his comm unit, then back up again.

We follow behind him as he steps towards a small kiosk built into the wall, Mordrun taps his badge against the screen, "ping", and the kiosk slides a paper cup beneath the dispenser and begins pouring. "Attention personnel and registered residents," a calm feminine voice interrupts the hum of the concourse. Mordrun looks up. "Today's Great Volunteering selections have been stamped. Selected personnel are reminded to report promptly to their assigned intake locations." The coffee finishes pouring and the kiosk responds in a synthesized voice, "Safe travels." Mordrun reaches for it. "Mordrun Stronglimb. Report for intake, Concourse 4, service desk 18."

His hand stops.

The coffee sits there for a moment as drips of dark black liquid splat into the cup.

"Abigail Benford, PPPP, Zed Zaffer, and Mordrun Stronglimb. Report for intake, Concourse 4, service desk 18."

He takes the cup. He turns from the kiosk, attempting to steel himself, and begins walking. His pace at first casual, then awkwardly quick, then faster. We follow him as he brushes through the flow of the crowd moving in the opposite direction. The coffee and his identification badge clatter to the ground as Mordrun slams into someone before breaking into a full on sprint. He pants and coughs, but as he presses forward it feels as though no progress is made. Then he hears it and a cold chill runs down his spine, "Mordrun?"

An older dwarven woman catches up from behind him, "There you are, I thought you'd already gotten to the platform." Mordrun shakes his head, trying to muster a word, but having finally stopped running, all he can do is heave from exertion. She looks at him, then towards the nearest information screen where the Great Volunteering emblem sits in the corner. "Oh."

Mordrun's breathing becomes faster. The woman steps closer, lowering her voice, "Hey, look at me. They haven't even told you where you're going yet." Mordrun looks up to make eye contact. "I know. I know. You've spent thirty years telling everyone else that Stronglimbs don't run from what they're given. So don't start running now." Mordrun looks towards the departure gates. "Whatever they've drawn you for, you'll do it, you'll

come back, and then you'll complain about it for the next twenty years like you do everything else." She smiles, but Mordrun doesn't. A moment passes. She sighs, "Take a moment to collect yourself. But, then you need to go."

We stay on Mordrun. His shoulders rise, fall, rise again. His eyes close.

"Second notice. Abigail Benford and Mordrun Stronglimb. Report for intake, Concourse 4, service desk 18. Failure to report may result in enforcement measures." rings out as we zoom out and fade to black.

Feet kick idly against the edge of a divider, 15 feet in the air, above the crowd. Around the area, the station continues normally, people passing in either direction, luggage rolling against the floor, the distant sound of a crowd chanting somewhere deeper in Theosis. We see the turn of a page. The text is simple, but he pauses as the words resonate deep within him: "We must go on, because we can't turn back." He looks up and we see a screen.

A large display screen above the concourse shows a ship passing through the Drift, replaced by a survey team stepping onto the surface of an unfamiliar planet. "See what waits beyond the Settled Systems. Volunteering gives ordinary citizens the opportunity to serve beside the renowned explorers, technicians, settlers, and specialists bringing civilization farther than ever before." The screen changes, a pilot sits at the controls of a small vessel, the stars stretching beyond the glass. "Serve where you're needed. Travel where others can't. Bring home the stars."

One last time, we hear over an intercom, "Attention personnel and registered residents. The following selected personnel remain outstanding for Great Volunteering intake: Abigail Benford, lashunta, age 20; Mordrun Stronglimb, dwarf, age 38. If encountered, please direct either individual immediately to Concourse 4, service desk 18. Enforcement procedures will begin in 10 offsets." He takes one more look at his book, then the advertisements on the screen, then the service desk off in the distance. A moment of deliberation. Then...a decision is made. He rifles through his bag, pulls out an armlet, and straps it on before hopping down from the ledge.

The next thing we see is service desk 18. An unamused, disinterested clerk spots the approaching dwarf, looking around as if unsure where to go. She glances at the terminal in front of her, and calls out, "Mordrun Stronglimb?" He looks nervous, but replies "Yes, Mr. Stronglimb reporting for duty, ma'am."

She types his name into the terminal. A red box appears on the edge of her screen. **VISUAL RECORD UNAVAILABLE** She looks up expectantly. He cracks a timid, somewhat confused smile. Ignoring his dismay, she plainly asks, "Badge?" He blinks. A pause. He starts patting down his jacket, "I... lost it?" The woman stares at him. Back towards the concourse general area, we cut briefly to two men shouting at one another, gesticulating wildly as a luggage cart tips onto its side. Someone begins yelling for security. We cut back. The woman glances towards the disturbance, then back towards the dwarf. Another notification appears on her terminal. **IDENTITY ARCHIVE SERVICE INTERRUPTION - MANUAL PROCESSING REQUIRED** "Of course," She turns the screen slightly, "Hand." He gingerly places his hand against the scanner, "Ouch.", but

jerks his hand away after a stink of pain. A small bead of blood is left against the glass. The scanner flashes green as something inside begins to whirl, a loading symbol spinning beside his name. It stutters, stops, and the terminal responds with another dull tone. **BIOMETRIC SAMPLE PROCESSING FAILURE - MANUAL PROCESSING REQUIRED**

The woman stares at the message, rubbing between her eyes with two fingers. "You're eighteen offsets late," she drones. "I couldn't find the desk." Behind the woman is a large sign reading **GREAT VOLUNTEERING - DESK 18**. She looks at the sign. He follows her eyes and looks at it too. The woman looks back towards her terminal. Security runs past behind them towards the argument as it escalates, one of the men shoving the other into the overturned luggage cart. The sound of an ancient printer churning begins somewhere behind the desk before jamming with a grinding "krrk-krrk-krrk". The woman closes her eyes for a moment.

"Mr. Stronglimb, are you reporting for your assigned Great Volunteering service?"

"Yes ma'am."

"Voluntarily?"

She opens her eyes. He nods. The meek smile is still there. A moment passes. "Fine." She turns back towards the terminal and manually confirms the intake. Another warning appears, **IDENTITY VERIFICATION PENDING - TEMPORARY CREDENTIALS AUTHORIZED**. She slides a temporary service badge across the desk. He takes it, staring at the name printed across the front. "Sign here." She pulls a piece of analog paper from beneath the desk and slides it to him with a ball-pen. We look down at the form as he carefully signs "Mordrun Stronglimb" above the dotted line.